

'Place de Grève?'

'Yes; don't you like this quarter?'

'On the contrary, the look-out over the water is pleasant. Oh! what a pretty old house!'

'The sign Notre Dame; it is an old cabaret, which I have transformed into a private house in two days.'

'But the cabaret is still open?'

'*Pardieu!*'

'And where do you lodge, then?'

'I? I lodge with Planchet.'

'You said, just now, "This is my house."'

'I said so, because, in fact, it is my house. I have bought it.'

'Ah! said Raoul.'

'At ten years' purchase, my dear Raoul; a superb affair; I bought the house for thirty thousand livres; it has a garden which opens to the Rue de la Mortillerie; the cabaret lets for a thousand livres, with the first story; the garret, or second floor, for five hundred livres.'

'Indeed!'

'Yes, indeed.'

'Five hundred livres for a garret? Why, it is not habitable.'

'Therefore no one inhabits it; only, you see, this garret has two windows which look out upon the Place.'

'Yes, monsieur.'

'Well, then, every time anybody is broken on the wheel or hung, quartered, or burnt, these two windows let for twenty pistoles.'

'Oh! said Raoul, with horror.'

'It is disgusting, is it not?' said D'Artagnan.

'Oh! repeated Raoul.'

'It is disgusting, but so it is. These Parisian cockneys are sometimes real anthropophagi. I cannot conceive how men, Christians, can make such speculation.'

'That is true.'

'As for myself,' continued D'Artagnan, 'if I inhabited that house, on days of execution I would shut it up to the very keyholes; but I do not inhabit it.'

'And you let the garret for five hundred livres?'

'To the ferocious cabaretier, who sub-lets it. I said, then, fifteen hundred livres.'

'The natural interest of money,' said Raoul, — 'five per cent.'

'Exactly so. I then have left the side of the house at the back, store-rooms, and cellars, inundated every winter, two hundred livres; and the garden, which is very fine, well planted, well shaded under the walls and the portal of Saint-Gervais-Saint-Protais, thirteen hundred livres.'

'Thirteen hundred livres! why, that is royal!'

'This is the whole history. I strongly suspect some canon of the parish (these canons are all rich as Croesus)—I suspect some canon of having hired the garden to take his pleasure in. The tenant has given the name of M. Godard. That is either a false name or a real name; if true, he is a canon; if false, he is some unknown; but of what consequence is it to me? he always pays in advance. I had also an idea just now, when I met you, of buying a house in the Place Baudoyer, the back premises of which join my garden, and would make a magnificent property. Your dragons interrupted my calculations. But come, let us take the Rue de la Vannerie: that will lead us straight to M. Planchet's.' D'Artagnan mended his pace, and conducted Raoul to Planchet's dwelling, a chamber of which the grocer had given up to his old master. Planchet was out, but the dinner was ready. There was a remains of military regularity and punctuality preserved in the grocer's household. D'Artagnan returned to the subject of Raoul's future.

'Your father brings you up rather strictly?' said he.

'Justly, monsieur le chevalier.'

'Oh, yes, I know Athos is just; but close, perhaps?'

'A royal hand, Monsieur d'Artagnan.'

'Well, never want, my boy! If ever you stand in need of a few pistoles, the old musketeer is at hand.'

'My dear Monsieur d'Artagnan!'

'Do you play a little?'

'Never.'

'Successful with the ladies, then?—Oh! my little Aramis! That, my dear friend, costs even more than play. It is true we fight when we lose; that is a compensation. Bah! that little sniveller, the king, makes winners give him his revenge. What a reign! my poor Raoul, what a reign! When

we think that, in my time, the musketeers were besieged in their houses like Hector and Priam in the city of Troy; and the women wept, and then the walls laughed, and then five hundred beggarly fellows clapped their hands and cried, "Kill! kill!" when not one musketeer was hurt. *Mordieux!* you will never see anything like that.'

'You are very hard upon the king, my dear Monsieur d'Artagnan and yet you scarcely know him.'

'I! Listen, Raoul. Day by day, hour by hour,—take note of my words,—I will predict what he will do. The cardinal being dead, he will fret; very well, that is the least silly thing he will do, particularly if he does not shed a tear.'

'And then?'

'Why, then he will get M. Fouquet to allow him a pension, and will go and compose verses at Fontainebleau, upon some Mancini or other, whose eyes the queen will scratch out. She is a Spaniard, you see,—this queen of ours; and she has, for mother-in-law, Madame Anne of Austria. I know something of the Spaniards of the house of Austria.'

'And next?'

'Well, after having torn the silver lace from the uniforms of his Swiss, because lace is too expensive, he will dismount his musketeers, because oats and hay of a horse cost five sols a day.'

'Oh! do not say that.'

'Of what consequence is it to me? I am no longer a musketeer, am I? Let them be on horseback, let them be on foot, let them carry a larding-pin, a spit, a sword, or nothing—what is it to me?'

'My dear Monsieur d'Artagnan, I beseech you speak no more ill of the king. I am almost in his service, and my father would be very angry with me for having heard, even from your mouth, words injurious to his majesty.'

'Your father, eh! He is a knight in every bad cause. *Pardieu!* yes, your father is a brave man, a Caesar, it is true—but a man without perception.'

'Now, my dear chevalier,' exclaimed Raoul, laughing, 'are you going to speak ill of my father, of him you call the great Athos? Truly you are in a bad vein to-day; riches render you as sour as poverty renders other people.'

done with Italian hands; leave the little snivelling king, who is going to give us another reign of Francis II. Do you know anything of history, Raoul?'

'Yes, monsieur le chevalier.'

'Do you know, then, that Francis II had always the carache?'

'No, I did not know that.'

'That Charles IV had always the headache?'

'Indeed!'

'And Henry III had always the stomach-ache?'

Raoul began to laugh.

'Well, my dear friend, Louis XIV always has the heart-ache; it is deplorable to see a king sighing from morning till night without saying once in the course of the day, *ventre-saint-gris! corbeil!* or anything to rouse one.'

'Was that the reason why you quitted the service, monsieur le chevalier?'

'Yes.'

'But you yourself, M. d'Artagnan, are throwing the handle after the axe; you will not make a fortune.'

'Who? I?' replied D'Artagnan, in a careless tone; 'I am settled—I had some family property.'

Raoul looked at him. The poverty of D'Artagnan was proverbial. A Gascon, he exceeded in ill-luck all the gasconades of France and Navarre; Raoul had a hundred times heard Job and D'Artagnan named together, as the twins Romulus and Remus. D'Artagnan caught Raoul's look of astonishment.

'And has not your father told you I have been in England?'

'Yes, monsieur le chevalier.'

'And that I there met with a very lucky chance?'

'No, monsieur, I did not know that.'

'Yes, a very worthy friend of mine, a great nobleman, the viceroy of Scotland and Ireland, has endowed me with an inheritance.'

'An inheritance?'

'And a good one, too.'

'Then you are rich?'

'Bah!'

'Receive my sincere congratulation.'

'Thank you! Look, that is my house.'

'Most willingly, Monsieur d'Artagnan.'

'Be quick, then; leave your horse, or make them give me one.'

'I prefer coming back on foot with you.'

Raoul hastened to give notice to the cornet, who took his post; he then dismounted, gave his horse to one of the dragoons, and with great delight seized the arm of M. d'Artagnan, who had watched him during all these little evolutions with the satisfaction of a connoisseur.

'What, do you come from Vincennes?' said he.

'Yes, monsieur le chevalier.'

'And the cardinal?'

'Is very ill; it is even reported he is dead.'

'Are you on good terms with M. Fouquet?' asked D'Artagnan, with a disdainful movement of the shoulders, proving that the death of Mazarin did not affect him beyond measure.

'With M. Fouquet?' said Raoul; 'I do not know him.'

'So much the worse! so much the worse! for a new king always seeks to get good men in his employment.'

'Oh! the king means no harm,' replied the young man.

'I say nothing about the crown,' cried D'Artagnan; 'I am speaking of the king—the king, that is M. Fouquet, if the cardinal is dead. You must contrive to stand well with M. Fouquet, if you do not wish to moulder away all your life as I have mouldered. It is true you have, fortunately, other protectors.'

'M. le Prince, for instance.'

'Worn out! worn out!'

'M. le Comte de la Fère?'

'Athos! Oh! that's different; yes, Athos—and if you have any wish to make your way in England, you cannot apply to a better person; I can even say, without too much vanity, that I myself have some credit at the court of Charles II. There is a king—God speed him!'

'Ah!' cried Raoul, with the natural curiosity of well-born young people, while listening to experience and courage.

'Yes, a king who amuses himself, it is true, but who has had a sword in his hand, and can appreciate useful men. Athos is on good terms with Charles II. Take service there, and leave these scoundrels of contractors and farmers-general, who steal as well with French hands as others have

'*Pardieu!* you are right. I am a rascal and in my dotage; I am an unhappy wretch grown old; a tent-cord untwisted, a pierced cuirass, a boot without a sole, a spur without a rowel;—but do me the pleasure to add one thing.'

'What is that, my dear Monsieur d'Artagnan?'

'Simply say: "Mazarin was a pitiful wretch."'

'Perhaps he is dead.'

'More the reason—I say was; if I did not hope that he was dead, I would entreat you to say: "Mazarin is a pitiful wretch." Come, say so, say so, for love of me.'

'Well, I will.'

'Say it!'

'Mazarin was a pitiful wretch,' said Raoul, smiling at the musketeer, who roared with laughter, as in his best days.

'A moment,' said the latter; 'you have spoken my first proposition, here is the conclusion of it,—repeat, Raoul, repeat: "But I regret Mazarin."'

'Chevalier!'

'You will not say it? Well, then, I will say it twice for you.'

'But you would regret Mazarin?'

And they were still laughing and discussing this profession of principles, when one of the shop-boys entered. 'A letter, monsieur,' said he, 'for M. d'Artagnan.'

'Thank you; give it me,' cried the musketeer.

'The handwriting of monsieur le comte,' said Raoul.

'Yes, yes.' And D'Artagnan broke the seal.

'Dear friend,' said Athos, 'a person has just been here to beg me to seek for you, on the part of the king.'

'Seek me!' said D'Artagnan, letting the paper fall upon the table. Raoul picked it up, and continued to read aloud:—

'Make haste. His majesty is very anxious to speak to you, and expects you at the Louvre.'

'Expects me?' again repeated the musketeer.

'He, he, he!' laughed Raoul.

'Oh, oh!' replied D'Artagnan. 'What the devil can this mean?'

Chapter III

D'Artagnan's Lesson



RAOUL did not meet with D'Artagnan the next day, as he had hoped. He only met with Planchet, whose joy was great at seeing the young man again, and who contrived to pay him two or three little soldierly compliments, savouring very little of the grocer's shop. But as Raoul was returning the next day from Vincennes at the head of fifty dragoons confided to him by Monsieur le Prince, he perceived, in La Place Baudoyer, a man with his nose in the air, examining a house as we examine a horse we have a fancy to buy. This man, dressed in a citizen costume buttoned up like a military *pourpoint*, a very small hat on his head, but a long shagreen-mounted sword by his side, turned his head as soon as he heard the steps of the horses, and left off looking at the house to look at the dragoons. It was simply M. d'Artagnan; D'Artagnan on foot; D'Artagnan with his hands behind him, passing a little review upon the dragoons, after having reviewed the buildings. Not a man, not a tag, not a horse's hoof escaped his inspection. Raoul rode at the side of his troop; D'Artagnan perceived him the last. 'Eh?' said he, 'Eh! *Mordieu*!'

'I was not mistaken!' cried Raoul, turning his horse towards him.

'Mistaken—no! Good-day to you,' replied the ex-musketeer; whilst Raoul eagerly pressed the hand of his old friend. 'Take care, Raoul,' said D'Artagnan, 'the second horse of the fifth rank will lose a shoe before he gets to the Pont Marie; he has only two nails left in his off fore-foot.'

'Wait a minute, I will come back,' said Raoul.

'Can you quit your detachment?'

'The cornet is there to take my place.'

'Then you will come and dine with me?'

Chapter LIII

The King



THE first moment of surprise over, D'Aragan repurposed Athos's note. 'It is strange,' said he, 'that the king should send for me.'

'Why so?' said Raoul; 'do you not think, monsieur, that the king must regret such a servant as you?'

'Oh, oh!' cried the officer, laughing with all his might; 'you are poking fun at me, Master Raoul. If the king had regretted me, he would not have let me leave him. No, no; I see in it something better, or worse, if you like.'

'Worse! What can that be, monsieur le chevalier?'

'You are young, you are a boy, you are admirable. Oh, how I should like to be as you are! To be but twenty-four, with an unfortunate brow, under which the brain is void of everything but women, love, and good intentions. Oh, Raoul, as long as you have not received the smiles of kings, the confidence of queens; as long as you have not had two cardinals killed under you, the one a tiger, the other a fox; as long as you have not—But what is the good of all this trifling? We must part, Raoul.'

'How you say the word! What a serious face!'

'Eh! but the occasion is worthy of it. Listen to me. I have a very good recommendation to tender you.'

'I am all attention, Monsieur d'Aragan.'

'You will go and inform your father of my departure.'

'Your departure?'

'*Pardieu!* You will tell him I am gone into England; and that I am living in my little country-house.'

'In England, you!—And the king's orders?'

'You get more and more silly: do you imagine that I am going to the Louvre, to place myself at the disposal of that little crowned wolf-cub?'

'The king a wolf-cub? Why, monsieur le chevalier, you are mad!'

'On the contrary, I never was so sane. You do not know what he wants to do with me, this worthy son of Louis le Justel!—But, *mordieu!* that is policy. He wishes to ensconce me snugly in the Bastille—purely and simply, look you!'

'What for?' cried Raoul, terrified at what he heard.

'On account of what I told him one day at Blois. I was warm; he remembers it.'

'You told him what?'

'That he was mean, cowardly, and silly.'

'Good God!' cried Raoul, 'is it possible that such words should have issued from your mouth?'

'Perhaps I don't give the letter of my speech, but I give the sense of it.'

'But did not the king have you arrested immediately?'

'By whom? It was I who commanded the musketeers; he must have commanded me to convey myself to prison; I would never have consented: I would have resisted myself. And then I went into England—no more D'Artagnan. Now, the cardinal is dead, or nearly so, they learn that I am in Paris, and they lay their hands on me.'

'The cardinal was your protector?'

'The cardinal knew me; he knew certain particularities of me; I also knew some of his; we appreciated each other mutually. And then, on rendering his soul to the devil, he would recommend Anne of Austria to make me the inhabitant of a safe place. Go, then, and find your father, relate the fact to him—and adieu!'

'My dear Monsieur d'Artagnan,' said Raoul, very much agitated, after having looked out the window, 'you cannot even fly!'

'Why not?'

'Because there is below an officer of the Swiss guards waiting for you.'

'Well?'

'Well, he will arrest you.'

D'Artagnan broke into a Homeric laugh.

'No; at present M. d'Artagnan is absent on leave; he is resting for awhile. Do not, therefore, seek him at the posts of his service. You will hear of him at the house of a certain Planchet.'

'His former lackey?'

'Exactly; turned grocer.'

'I know; Rue des Lombards?'

'Somewhere thereabouts, or Rue des Arcis.'

'I will find it, monsieur—I will find it.'

'You will say a thousand kind things to him, on my part, and ask him to come and dine with me before I set out for La Fère.'

'Yes, monsieur.'

'Good-night, Raoul!'

'Monsieur, I see you wear an order I never saw you wear before; accept my compliments.'

'The Fleece!—that is true. A bauble, my boy; which no longer amuses an old child like myself. Good-night, Raoul!'

forward, we must go even to exceptions, even to improbabilities! If, I say, Mademoiselle de La Vallière should not wait for you?

'How, monsieur?'

'If she turned her eyes another way.'

'If she looked favourably upon another, do you mean, monsieur?' said Raoul, pale with agony.

'Exactly.'

'Well, monsieur, I would kill him,' said Raoul, simply, 'and all the men whom Mademoiselle de La Vallière should choose, until one of them had killed me, or Mademoiselle de La Vallière had restored me her heart.'

Athos started. 'I thought,' resumed he, in an agitated voice, 'that you called my just now your god, your law in this world.'

'Oh!' said Raoul, trembling, 'you would forbid me the duel?'

'Suppose I did forbid it, Raoul?'

'You would not forbid me to hope, monsieur; consequently you would not forbid me to die.'

Athos raised his eyes toward the vicomte. He had pronounced these words with the most melancholy look. 'Enough,' said Athos, after a long silence, 'enough of this subject, upon which we both go too far. Live as well as you are able, Raoul, perform your duties, love Mademoiselle de La Vallière; in a word, act like a man, since you have attained the age of a man; only do not forget that I love you tenderly, and that you profess to love me.'

'Ah! monsieur le comte!' cried Raoul, pressing the hand of Athos to his heart.

'Enough, dear boy, leave me; I want rest. À propos, M. d'Aragnan has returned from England with me; you owe him a visit.'

'I will pay it, monsieur, with great pleasure. I love Monsieur d'Aragnan exceedingly.'

'You are right in doing so; he is a worthy man and a brave cavalier.'

'Who loves you dearly.'

'I am sure of that. Do you know his address?'

'At the Louvre, I suppose, or wherever the king is. Does he not command the musketeers?'

'Oh! I know very well that you will resist, that you will fight, even; I know very well that you will prove the conqueror; but that amounts to rebellion, and you are an officer yourself, knowing what discipline is.'

'Devil of a boy, how logical that is!' grumbled D'Aragnan.

'You approve of it, do you not?'

'Yes, instead of passing into the street, where that idiot is waiting for me, I will slip quietly out at the back. I have a horse in the stable, and a good one. I will ride him to death; my means permit me to do so, and by killing one horse after another, I shall arrive at Boulogne in eleven hours; I know the road. Only tell your father one thing.'

'What is that?'

'That is—that the thing he knows about is placed at Planchet's house, except a fifth, and that—'

'But, my dear D'Aragnan, rest assured that if you fly, two things will be said of you.'

'What are they, my dear friend?'

'The first, that you have been afraid.'

'Ah! and who will dare to say that?'

'The king first.'

'Well! but he will tell the truth,—I am afraid.'

'The second, that you knew yourself guilty.'

'Guilty of what?'

'Why, of the crimes they wish to impure to you.'

'That is true again. So, then, you advise me to go and get myself made a prisoner in the Bastille?'

'M. le Comte de la Fère would advise you just as I do.'

'*Parbleu!* I know he would,' said D'Aragnan thoughtfully. 'You are right, I shall not escape. But if they cast me into the Bastille?'

'We will get you out again,' said Raoul, with a quiet, calm air.

'*Mordieu!* You said that after a brave fashion, Raoul,' said D'Aragnan, seizing his hand, 'that savours of Athos, distinctly. Well, I will go, then. Do not forget my last word.'

'Except a fifth,' said Raoul.

'Yes, you are a fine boy! and I wish you to add one thing to that last word.'

'Speak, chevalier!'

'It is that if you cannot get me out of the Bastille, and I remain there—Oh! that will be so, and I shall be a detestable prisoner, I, who have been a passable man,—in that case, I give three-fifths to you, and the fourth to your father.'

'Chevalier!'

'*Mordieu!* If you will have some masses said for me, you are welcome.' That being said, D'Artagnan took his belt from the hook, girded on his sword, took a hat the feather of which was fresh, and held his hand out to Raoul, who threw himself into his arms. When in the shop, he cast a quick glance at the shop-lads, who looked upon the scene with a pride mingled with some inquietude; then plunging his hands into a chest of curranths, he went straight to the officer who was waiting for him at the door.

'Those features! Can it be you, Monsieur de Friedisch?' cried D'Artagnan, gayly. 'Eh! eh! what, do we arrest our friends?'

'Arrest!' whispered the lads among themselves.

'Ja, it is I, Monsieur d'Artagnan! Good-day to you!' said the Swiss, in his mountain patois.

'Must I give you up my sword? I warn you that it is long and heavy; you had better let me wear it to the Louvre: I feel quite lost in the streets without a sword, and you would be more at a loss that I should, with two.'

'The king has given me no orders about it,' replied the Swiss, 'so keep your sword.'

'Well, that is very polite on the part of the king. Let us go, at once.'

Monsieur Friedisch was not a talker, and D'Artagnan had too many things to think about to say much. From Planchet's shop to the Louvre was not far,—they arrived in ten minutes. It was a dark night. M. de Friedisch wanted to enter by the wicker. 'No,' said D'Artagnan, 'you would lose time by that; take the little staircase.'

The Swiss did as D'Artagnan advised, and conducted him to the vestibule of the king's cabinet. When arrived there, he bowed to his prisoner, and, without saying anything, returned to his post. D'Artagnan had not had time to ask why his sword was not taken from him, when the door of the cabinet opened, and a valet de chambre called, 'M. d'Artagnan!' The musketeer assumed his parade carriage, and entered, with his large eyes

'You are wrong,' said Athos, 'I have no longer any right over you. Age has emancipated you; you no longer even stand in need of my consent. Besides, I will not refuse my consent after what you have told me. Marry Mademoiselle de La Vallière, if you like.'

Raoul was startled, but suddenly: 'You are very kind, monsieur,' said he; 'and your concession excites my warmest gratitude, but I will not accept it.'

'Then you now refuse?'

'Yes, monsieur.'

'I will not oppose you in anything, Raoul.'

'But you have at the bottom of your heart an idea against this marriage: it is not your choice.'

'That is true.'

'That is sufficient to make me resist: I will wait.'

'Beware, Raoul! What you are now saying is serious.'

'I know it is, monsieur; as I said, I will wait.'

'Until I die?' said Athos, much agitated.

'Oh! monsieur,' cried Raoul, with tears in his eyes, 'is it possible that you should wound my heart thus? I have never given you cause of complaint!'

'Dear boy, that is true,' murmured Athos, pressing his lips violently together to conceal the emotion of which he was no longer master. 'No, I will no longer afflict you; only I do not comprehend what you mean by waiting. Will you wait till you love no longer?'

'Ah! for that!—no, monsieur. I will wait till you change your opinion.'

'I should wish to put the matter to a test, Raoul; I should like to see if Mademoiselle de La Vallière will wait as you do.'

'I hope so, monsieur.'

'But, take care, Raoul! suppose she did not wait? Ah, you are young, so confiding, so loyal! Women are changeable.'

'You have never spoken ill to me of women, monsieur; you have never had to complain of them; why should you doubt of Mademoiselle de La Vallière?'

'That is true,' said Athos, casting down his eyes; 'I have never spoken ill to you of women; I have never had to complain of them; Mademoiselle de La Vallière never gave birth to a suspicion; but when we are looking